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Diasporas and Dreams

> ‘Not one single person came here with the idea that they’d get married, settle down; they just wanted to earn money for a couple of years and go back.’
>
> —Palanisamy Kumaran, on migrating to the Malaya world in the 1930s[1]

Palanisamy Kumaran travelled from Nagapattinam in present-day Tamil Nadu to Penang in present-day Malaysia in 1937. He left with few possessions and a Rs 27 ticket for the steamer journey. He would live there for over seventy years but his initial memory of migration, as narrated and recounted before Sunil Amrith who recorded it in his magisterial book *Crossing the Bay of Bengal*, was not one towards permanent settlement. While Kumaran was initially a part of the Great Indian Migration Wave, he differed from the others by settling down in his destination instead of returning. Similar decisions by other migrant workers for a variety of reasons have, over time, contributed to the emergence of a vast Indian diaspora of over 25 million people across the world.[2] Depending on the vintage, it competes closely with the British and the Chinese in their claim to being the largest regional diaspora in the world.

The word ‘diaspora’, originally used to refer to the dispersal of Jews around the world, entered the Indian bureaucratic lexicon only in 2001 with the release of the *Report of the High Level Committee on the Indian*